Chapter 3

# Presenting with Copilot

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Most people hate creating PowerPoint presentations, sitting through PowerPoint presentations, and, especially, presenting PowerPoint presentations. Someone must enjoy them, however, because slide-based presentations of information remain the overwhelming choice of businesses everywhere. Whether they're online or in person, PowerPoint has been synonymous with "slide presentation" for a long time.

In this chapter, you learn about new AI features in PowerPoint that can make creating, viewing, and even presenting PowerPoint presentations easier, and (dare I say it) maybe even fun. You also learn how to use all these new AI powers to help (rather than replace) presentation authors, PowerPoint designers, and presenters.

## Interacting with Copilot in PowerPoint

When you open PowerPoint after subscribing to Microsoft 365 Copilot or Copilot Pro, you'll see the Copilot button at the right end of the Home tab of the Ribbon. Clicking this icon opens the Copilot sidebar in PowerPoint, as shown in Figure 3-1.

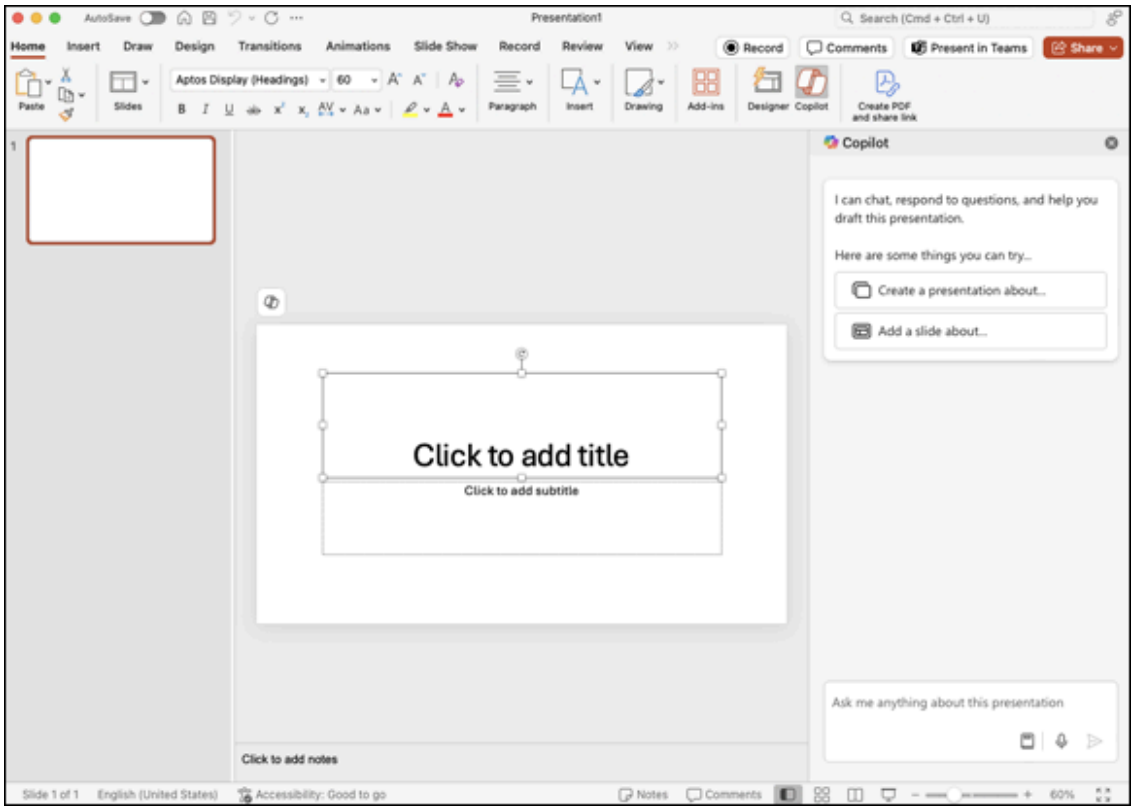



**FIGURE 3-1:** The Copilot sidebar in PowerPoint.

## Using Copilot's built-in PowerPoint actions

As you see in the Copilot sidebar when you first open it, Copilot in PowerPoint has two built-in actions that you can use to start a new presentation. These are

- Create a Presentation About
- Add a Slide About



**REMEMBER** The most important thing about built-in actions is that they must start with this exact command. If you change the words, CoPilot will usually claim not to be able to help you.

You can use either of these two actions by doing any of the following things:

- Click the button in the chat sidebar.
- Click the Copilot icon in the main slide window of PowerPoint.
- Choose the prompt you want from the View Prompts menu in the prompt input box.
- Type a phrase into the text input box manually.

In addition to these two slide-creation actions, there's also at least one more action called Add an Image Of. In this section, you see how to create a presentation from scratch using just these three tools. In the process, you learn more about the capabilities and limitations of Copilot in PowerPoint.

### Defining and refining your topic

Like Copilot Chat in any other application, Copilot in PowerPoint can answer questions about the content you're working on, and it can chat about any other topic as well (or at least pretend to).

Although these days, I spend most of my time typing, I sometimes get asked to talk — online or in person — about some aspect of what I do. I want to create a presentation that I can have ready in case this happens, and I'm going to use Copilot to help with it.

Honestly, I don't know what I want to talk about, but I'm hoping to brainstorm with Copilot to come up with an idea. I encourage you to follow along and modify the details to suit your interests and experiences.

The first thing I did was explain my goal to Copilot with the following prompt:

> *Help me brainstorm ideas. I'm an author of books about computer programming and AI, and I have to do a five-minute presentation to people who want to learn something about what I do. Give me ten ideas for presentation titles.*

The result of submitting this prompt is shown in Figure 3-2.

Copilot's first ten ideas weren't very good or relevant to what I wanted. I refined my prompt to make it clearer that the audience contains aspiring technical book authors.

> *Please try again; the audience is made up of aspiring technical book authors.*

This time, instead of responding to my prompt with a list in the chat sidebar, Copilot created ten slides with a proposed title and a description for each idea. It's not what I asked for, but I sort of like it. My favorite idea and slide from the ten options Copilot gave me is shown in Figure 3-3.

Since many of the books I write are *For Dummies* books, writing for my audience is a large part of what I do as an author. I wouldn't have chosen this particular image for the slide, but that's unimportant at this point.

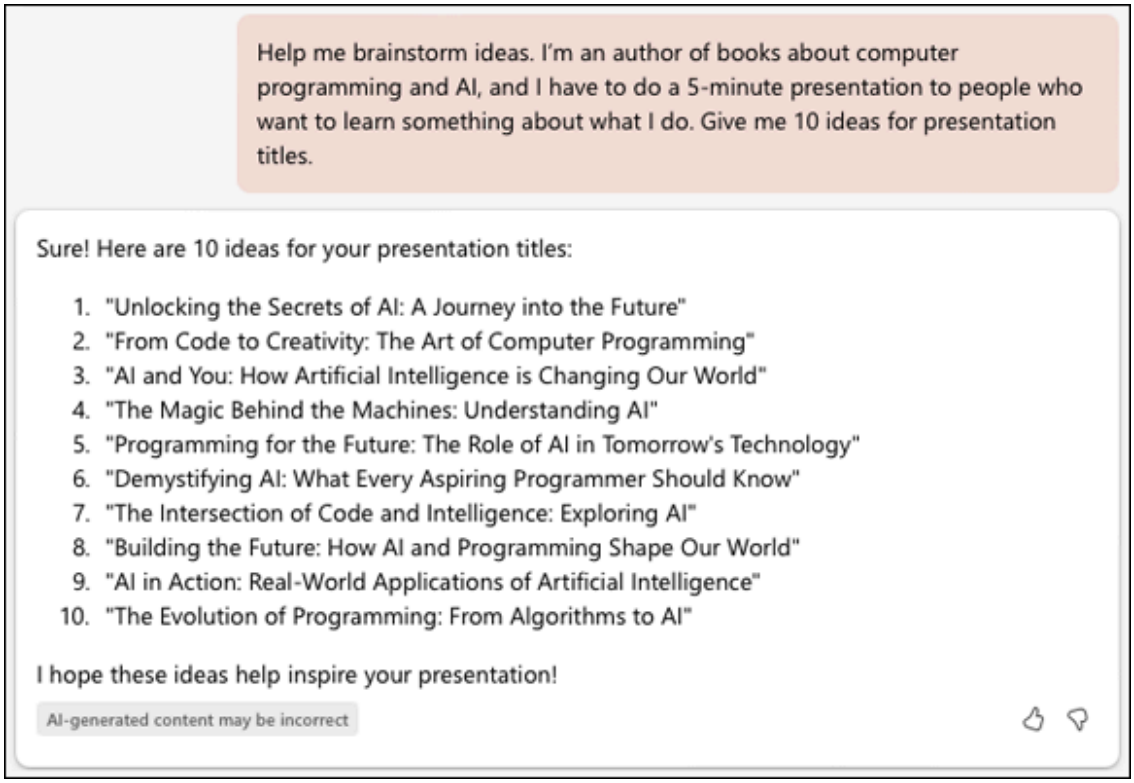



**FIGURE 3-2:** Copilot's first ideas for my talk.




*Hailshadow / Getty Images*

**FIGURE 3-3:** A generated slide and a proposed idea.



**REMEMBER** No one who reads my books is actually a "dummy." Reading a *For Dummies* book, as I interpret it, demonstrates Socratic wisdom. In other words, you, as a reader, know that you know little to nothing about a topic, but you're willing to learn and keep an open mind! This open-mindedness is what makes writing books *For Dummies* so much more interesting to me than writing books "for certified experts."

## Personalizing the idea

Once you have a basic idea for a talk, the next step is to make the idea your own. While ideas and sentences generated by Copilot may sound good at first, upon further inspection, they're always pretty bland and impersonal. Just using slides generated by Copilot without modifying them or rewriting them will result in a boring presentation.

Here are some tips for starting to personalize your presentation ideas:

- Think about stories and anecdotes from your own experience that are related to your presentation's theme.
- Think about images that might be great to use.

- Think about key points you want to make.

When you have some ideas about each of the preceding three points, you're ready to move on to creating the first draft of your presentation.



**WARNING** If you already have a presentation open when you submit a prompt starting with "Create a presentation about" you'll see a warning from Copilot that the new presentation will replace the existing slides, and you'll be asked to agree to this or to cancel creating the new presentation. In my case, I chose to overwrite the existing slides.

For my presentation, I wrote the following prompt:

> ***Create a presentation about*** *writing for your audience. The audience of this talk will be aspiring technical book authors. I want to convey that you should have a clear idea of your ideal reader in mind as you write and give some techniques for gaining that clarity, including creating a unique persona for them and giving your ideal reader a name.*

In less than a minute, Copilot created a presentation, which is partially shown in Figure 3-4.

So, how did it do?




**FIGURE 3-4:** A generated PowerPoint presentation.

## Evaluating the generated presentation

The presentation Copilot created consisted of nine slides, which were broken down as follows:

- One title slide
- One presentation overview slide
- One overview slide talking about techniques for gaining clarity about your ideal reader
- Two slides expanding on the techniques listed in the section overview
- One overview slide for a section about the benefits of writing for your audience
- Two slides expanding on the benefits of writing for your audience
- One conclusion slide

Ignoring the content for now, I like the structure of the presentation, and I can imagine it being a solid base to build my talk upon. I see now that Copilot interpreted my example technique for gaining clarity about your audience as two separate techniques. I could refine the prompt and try again, but I think after seeing what Copilot generated, I know how to fix it.

## Evaluating the generated content

Copilot did a good job of expanding on the brief ideas I mentioned in my prompt. The speaker notes Copilot generated are especially helpful and

even mention some topics I wouldn't have thought of. The slides themselves are too wordy for my taste. I prefer my slides to be sparse on text and memorable, rather than distracting from the presenter by forcing the audience to read them.

For example, Figure 3-5 shows the slide that Copilot created for the section overview page of the Benefits section.




**FIGURE 3-5:** Copilot's section overview page.

Figure 3-6 shows how I revised the content of this slide for an actual presentation.

## Evaluating the generated design

Even if I ended up completely rewriting the content of the presentation, I would likely keep much of the generated layout and template. The overall design, including the font choice and many of the picture choices, is better than I would have done myself and better than any presentation I've ever created by myself.

That's not saying much, of course. I'm not a graphic artist, and I've never taken the time to become a PowerPoint expert in spite of the fact that I need to create presentations on a regular basis. I suspect that most

PowerPoint users are like me and struggle with using anything but the most basic features of PowerPoint, but also don't have the desire to learn to use it correctly.




**FIGURE 3-6:** My revised slide is more succinct.

For a PowerPoint power user, Copilot in PowerPoint would probably be too hands-on to be helpful. However, for us perpetual PowerPoint klutzes, Copilot in PowerPoint is a miracle and may actually prevent more than a few ugly presentations.

## Evaluating the use of images

Images selected by Copilot in PowerPoint come from a library of stock art and have a typical stock art look. Although none of the selected images add much to the slides in terms of meaning, they're inoffensive, and they look professional. Furthermore, the overall design of the presentation is consistent. I've created presentations on my own that have much worse graphics. Again, if you're a graphic artist or have access to another library of stock art and the time, you could select or create better images. But, for a process that takes only a few minutes from creating a prompt to having a draft presentation, the images selected by Copilot and their placement on the slides are remarkably good.

No matter how good a generated presentation looks at first glance, it's never going to be exactly right. In fact, there's a good chance that most of it is wrong. After you see the first draft of a generated presentation, you have a choice to make — you can refine your prompt and try again, or you can start editing the presentation to make it your own.

Assuming you eventually get to the point at which you're ready to start editing a presentation, or if you have an existing presentation that wasn't generated by Copilot, move on to the next section to learn about using PowerPoint and Copilot's AI functionality for editing and improving presentations.

## Designing Slides with Designer

PowerPoint has a built-in slide design assistant called Designer that suggests possible variations on an existing slide's design. To access Designer, you can click the Designer button, which is next to the Copilot button in PowerPoint's ribbon, as shown in Figure 3-7.




**FIGURE 3-7:** The Designer button.

Designer is not powered by Copilot, and the designs it suggests tend to involve rearranging the existing content elements, adding animations, and changing the font sizes. In other words, Designer doesn't suggest radical changes, which is good because it only affects one slide at a time. If it did make big changes to the slide, you could easily end up with a presentation in which each slide has a different design (which is generally considered bad design).

Figure 3-8 shows the Designer pane on the right side of the PowerPoint interface, with several variations of a slide.

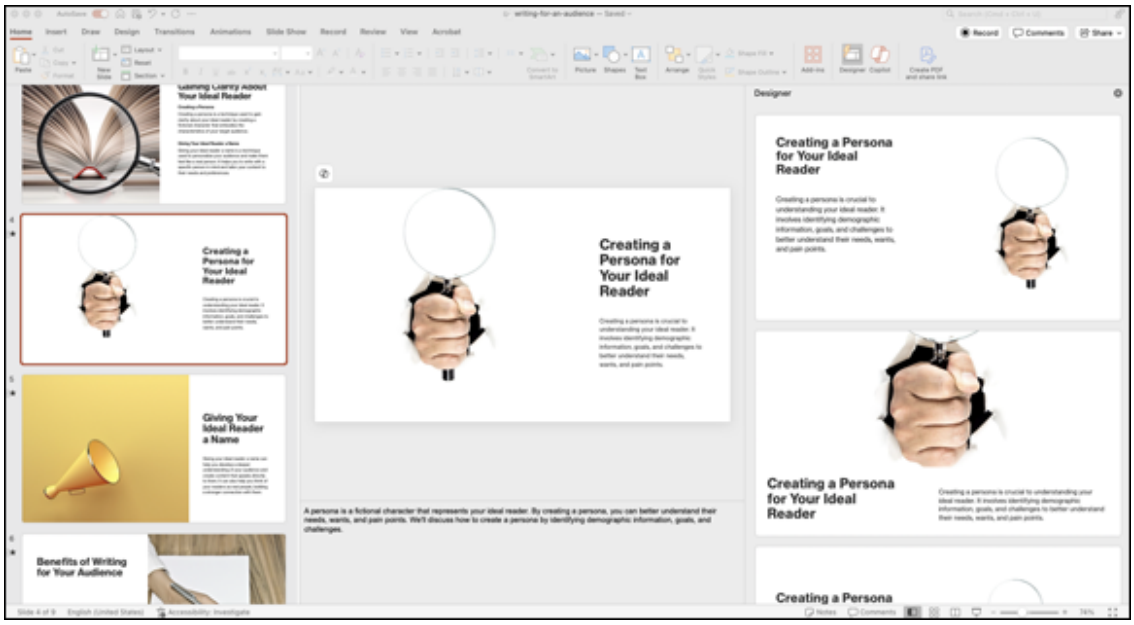



**FIGURE 3-8:** Layout options in the Designer pane.

## Redesigning Slides with Copilot

Copilot doesn't have the capability to directly edit slides that already exist in your presentation. This seems to be a pretty major limitation, and I suspect Copilot will gain this capability in the future. Figure 3-9 shows how Copilot in PowerPoint responds when I ask it to edit an existing slide.

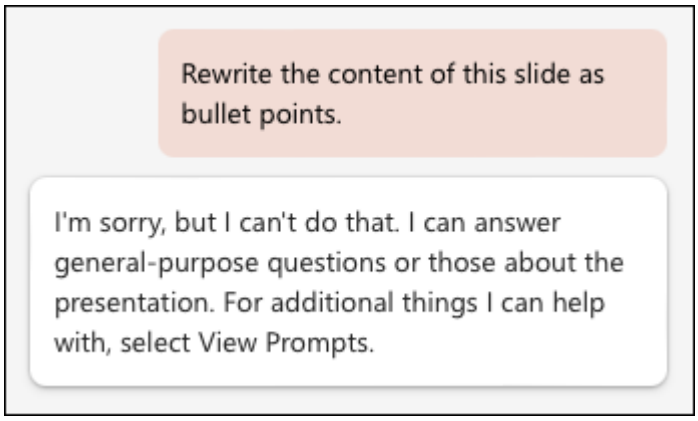



**FIGURE 3-9:** Copilot says it can't change a slide.



**TIP** As with everything involving AI chatbots, workarounds exist. It is possible to make a new slide that's based on an existing slide or slides. If the new slide is closer to what you want, you can then delete the previous slide.

The next thing I thought of trying was to ask Copilot to summarize a single slide in the presentation in bullet points. It also refused to do this. However, when I asked in a different way, Copilot responded with bullet points that summarize the entire presentation, as shown in Figure 3-10.

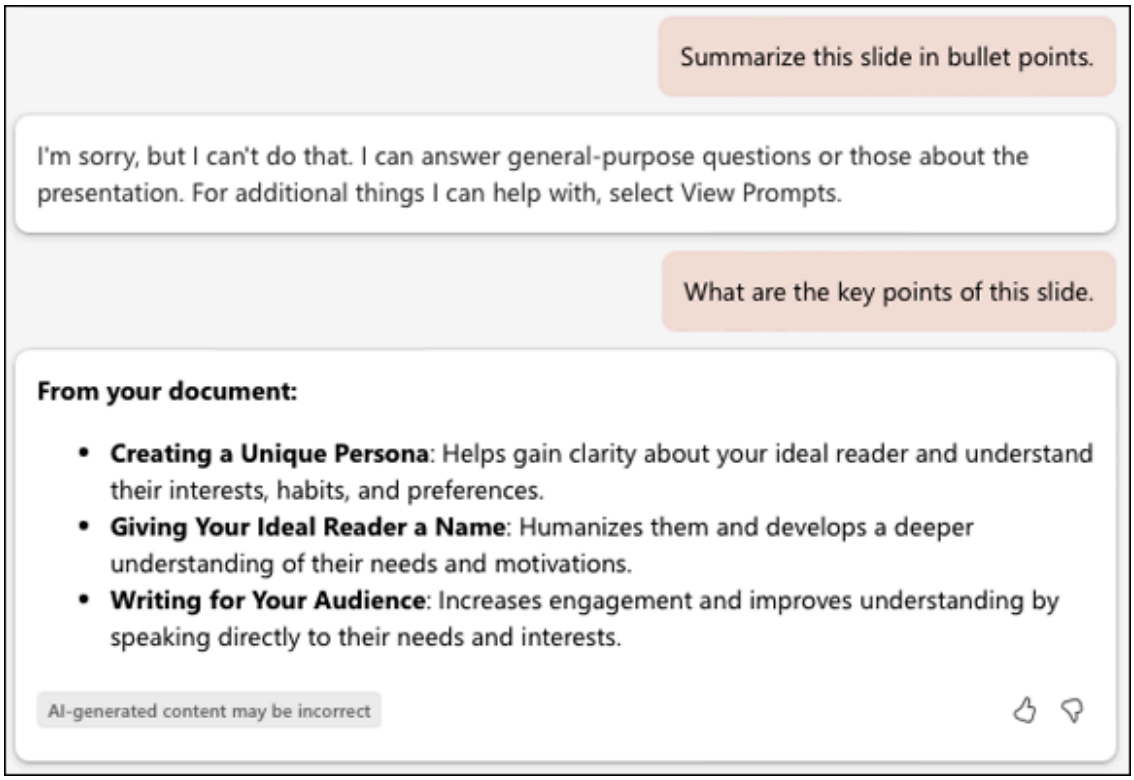



**FIGURE 3-10:** Figuring out what Copilot can and can't do is sometimes tricky.

## Sticking to the Built-in Prompts

Even more so than in other Microsoft 365 apps, Copilot in PowerPoint seems to have a strong preference for the short list of built-in prompts, and using prompts outside of this list produces highly unpredictable results.



**REMEMBER** You can access a list of the built-in prompts by clicking the View Prompts icon in the prompt input text area, just to the left of the Microphone icon.

The built-in action for creating a new slide is Add a Slide About. To get another option for an individual slide, I asked Copilot to add a slide about the topic of that slide with the following prompt:

***Add a Slide About** Creating a Persona for Your Ideal Reader*

In this case, asking Copilot to re-create a single slide was well worth it. The resulting slide is better than the first, in my opinion. It has more color, is warmer and more human, and uses bullet points rather than a single paragraph of text. The speaker notes are more detailed as well. Figure 3-11 shows the original slide, and Figure 3-12 shows the revised version.

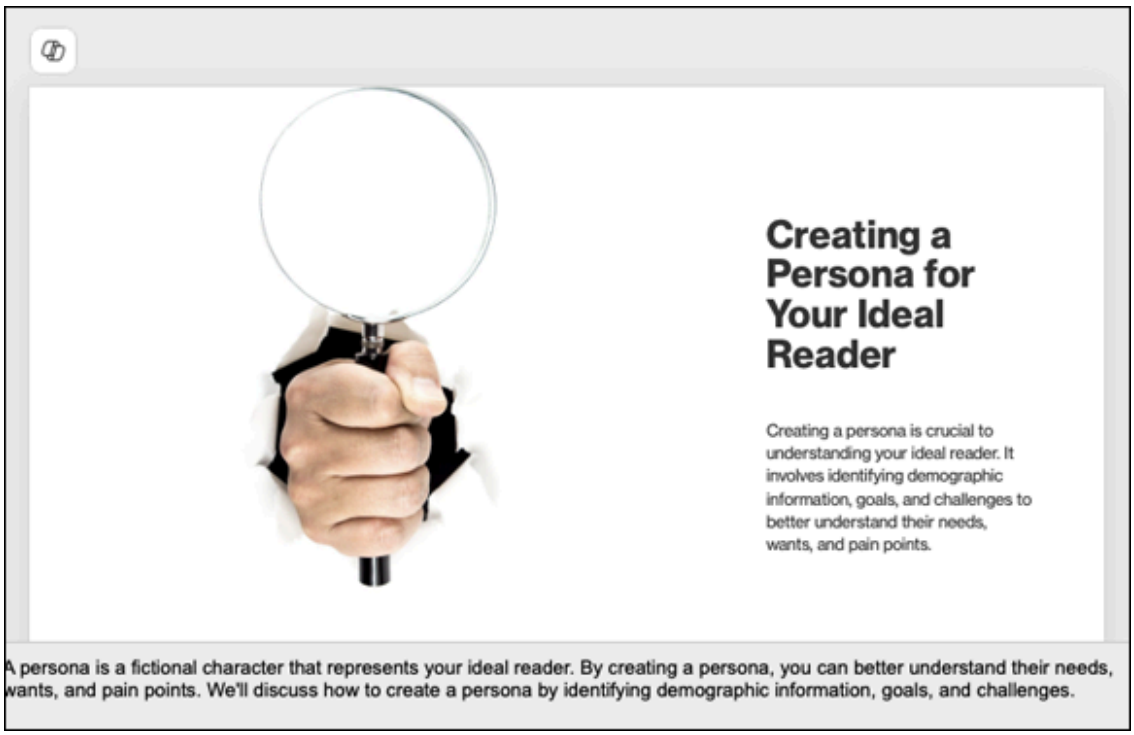



**FIGURE 3-11:** Copilot's first attempt.

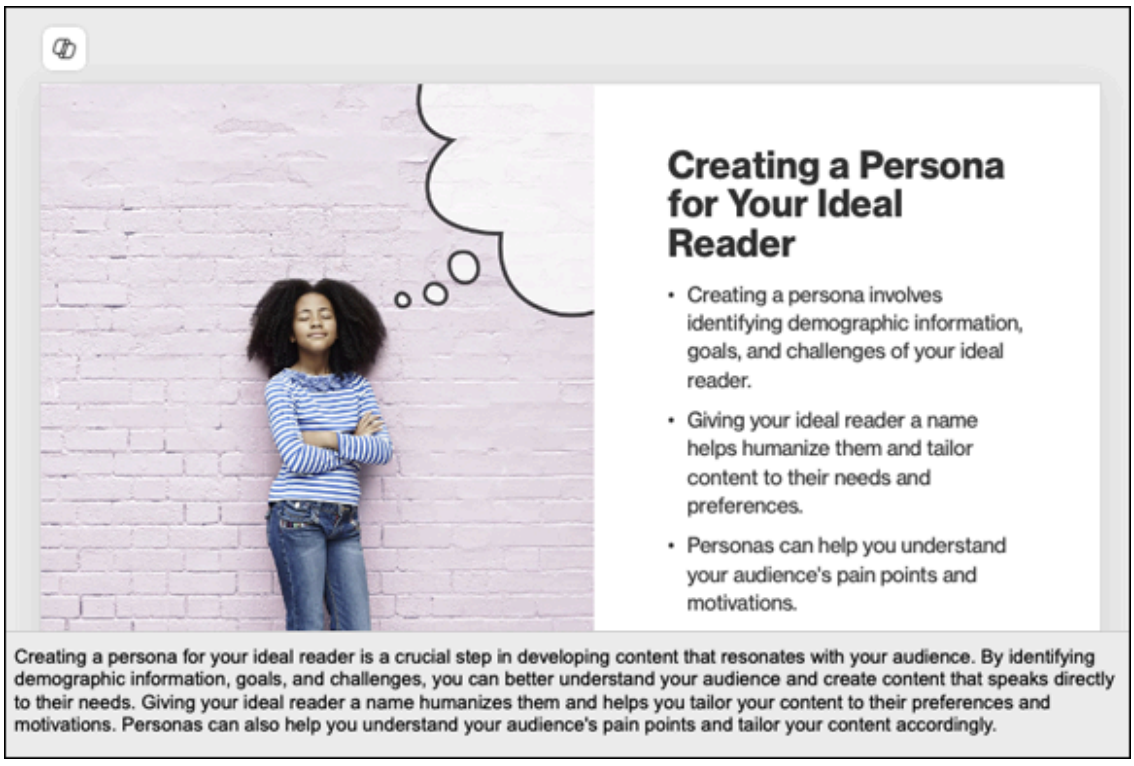


**FIGURE 3-12:** Copilot's second attempt.

## Enhancing visual appeal

Another one of Copilot in PowerPoint's built-in actions is Add an Image of. Using the Add an Image of action causes Copilot to attempt to locate an image that matches your request and add it to the slide you're currently editing.

Unlike the browser-based version of Copilot, Copilot in PowerPoint doesn't generate a new image for your prompt. Instead, Copilot in PowerPoint will search for an existing image in Microsoft's stock art collection. The new image will appear somewhere on the current slide, where you can resize and position it as you like.

## Prompting for images

Adding new images to existing slides is your opportunity to describe exactly the type of image that would make the slide more meaningful. However, depending on how imaginative and unique what you ask for is, you may find that what you get back from Copilot is completely wrong.

When using Copilot in PowerPoint's built-in prompts, don't worry that what you ask for isn't grammatically correct. Think of the built-in prompt as a command and whatever you put after that is what matters. For example, if you don't have a specific idea of what should be in an image, you can ask for an image of a concept. For example

> ***Add an Image of*** *Benefits of Writing for Your Audience.*

The result of this prompt, however, was not at all appropriate, as shown in Figure 3-13.




**FIGURE 3-13:** Copilot sometimes gets it very wrong.

You can get better results from the Add an Image of prompt if you have a specific and simple image that you want to add. For example, here's the next prompt I tried:

> ***Add an Image of*** *an audience applauding.*

The resulting image is shown in Figure 3-14.




*skynesher / Getty Images*

**FIGURE 3-14:** Simple, common, and specific images work better.

Because Copilot in PowerPoint adds images from a stock art library rather than generating new images using AI, you can be confident it won't contain hallucinations or any of the negative aspects of using generated images. On the other hand, because Copilot is limited to inserting stock art image, your more imaginative prompts won't produce anything like what you envisioned.

For example, in Figure 3-15, I prompted Copilot in PowerPoint to add an image of two cartoon frogs sitting at a small table drinking wine.




*kuritafsheen / Adobe Stock Photos*

**FIGURE 3-15:** Two frogs, but where's the rest of it?

For more creative images, you can use Copilot outside of PowerPoint to generate images. For example, I gave the same prompt to Copilot at `https://copilot.microsoft.com`, and it generated the image in Figure 3-16, which is much closer to what I imagined.



*Generated with AI using OpenAI*

**FIGURE 3-16:** The image created by Copilot Chat using DALL-E 3.



**REMEMBER** Book 4, Chapter 3 talks much more about creating and working with images using GenAI.

## Organizing a Presentation

Another built-in prompt is Organize this Presentation. This prompt will look at your presentation, add new slides and sections to it, and then tell you what it did.

Unlike the built-in prompts when using Copilot in Excel, Copilot in PowerPoint doesn't check with you before rearranging your presentation.

If you want to make sure you can restore your presentation to the state it was in before you asked Copilot to organize it, make sure to save a copy.



**WARNING** In my experience with the Organize this Presentation built-in action, the description of what it did to my presentation didn't exactly line up with what it *actually* did. Check your presentation carefully after using this prompt.

## Practicing Your Presentation with Copilot Feedback

PowerPoint's Rehearse with Coach feature uses AI to give you suggestions and feedback on your delivery of your presentation as you are practicing it and after you finish.

The feedback consists of standard best practices for public speaking. It will let you know if you're speaking too slowly or too quickly, whether you use a lot of "filler words" such as "um," and whether you are varying your voice enough to keep listeners interested.

To rehearse a presentation with an AI coach, select the Rehearse with Coach button from the Slide Show menu, as shown in Figure 3-17.




**FIGURE 3-17:** The Rehearse with Coach button.

Your presentation will start from the beginning, and the window shown in Figure 3-18 will appear.

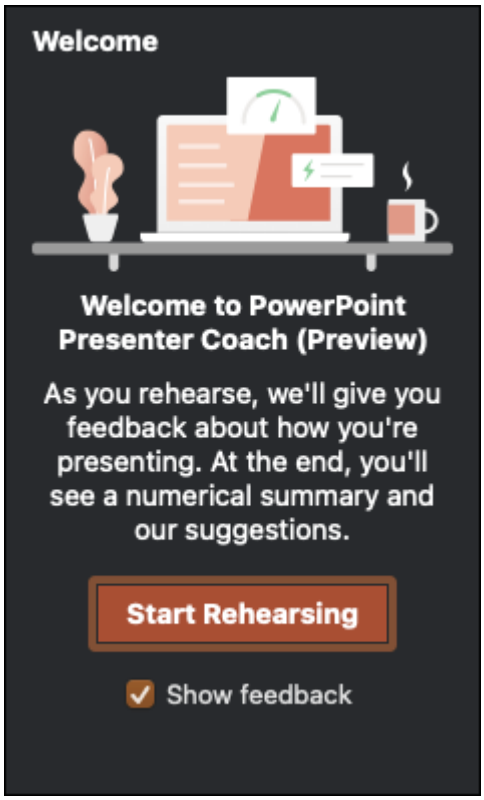



**FIGURE 3-18:** The Welcome window.

When you're ready to begin rehearsing, click the Start Rehearsing button. The AI presenter coach will start listening to you as you present and will occasionally give you real-time feedback.

Some of the things the coach is paying attention to as you rehearse include the following:

- Pacing
- Use of filler words (such as "you know," "um," and "like")
- Whether you're simply reading the presentation word for word
- The amount of variation in the pitch of your voice
- The amount of variety in your word choice

An example of real-time feedback you might get from the coach is shown in Figure 3-19. In this example, I reached a part of my presentation that I didn't feel confident about, and it showed in my use of "umm."

The coaching is really helpful, although the instant feedback can be distracting at first. The feedback you get from the coach isn't always negative. Sometimes it will just pop in to tell you that you're doing great, which is also nice.

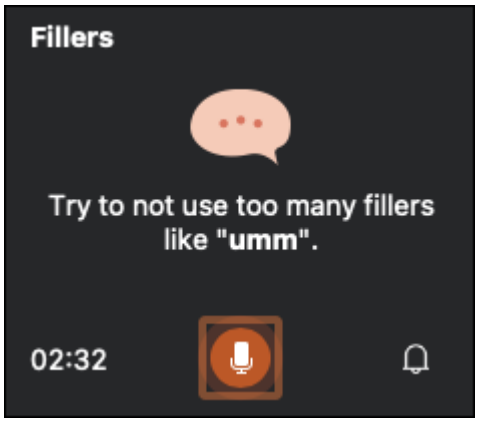



**FIGURE 3-19:** Avoid filler words.

When you've finished rehearsing, a final report like the one shown in Figure 3-20 will appear. It tells you how you did and what areas to concentrate on improving.

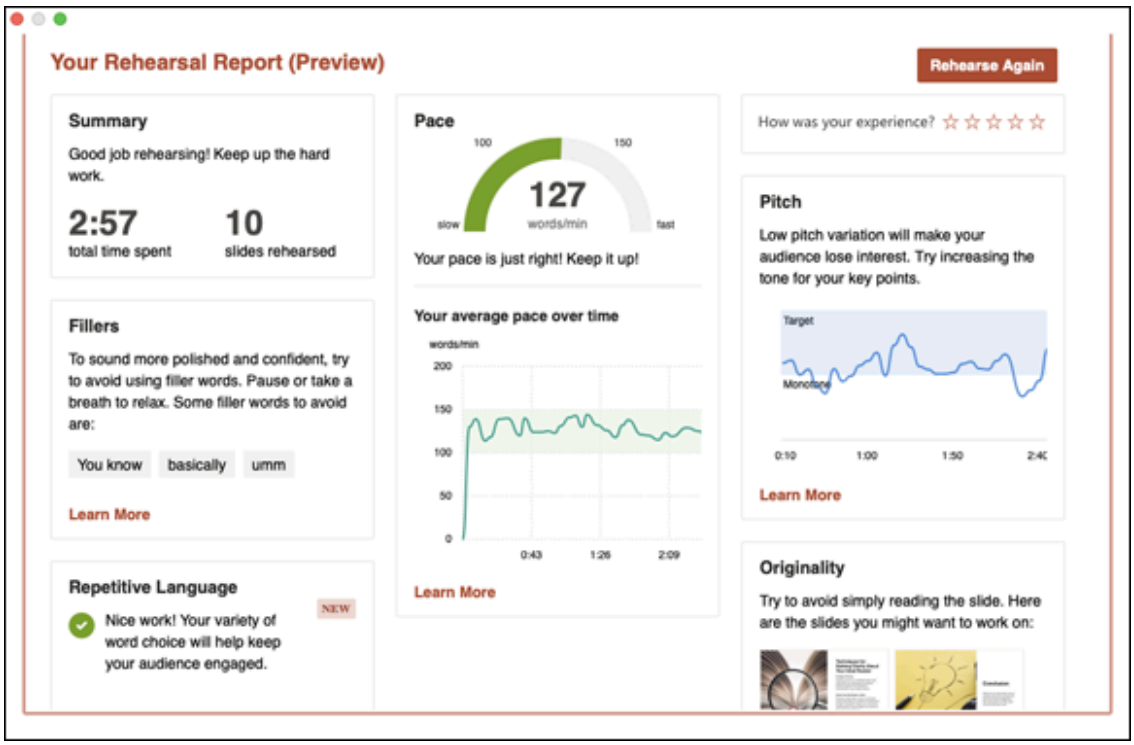



**FIGURE 3-20:** A sample rehearsal report.